

The Snowlit Fjords of the North

The snowlit fjords of the north run deep and blue between white mountains and dark green pines, dotted with cosy longhouses whose windows glow warm amber against the snow. Above them arches the Great World Tree, and on clear nights the sky dances with the colours of the aurora. The fjords are full of gentle wonders: a chattering squirrel who carries messages along the tree, two wise ravens, light spirits who dance in the dark, and frost giants who look fearsome but are mostly just cold and lonely. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who keeps a warm heart, thinks things through, and shares the fire. The grandest deeds are done by being clever and brave and kind, and even a giant met with a friendly word often turns out lonelier than it is fierce.



Who's Who and What's What

Places

The Frozen Fjord - A long, deep arm of blue water between the mountains, frozen smooth and silver in the heart of winter, easy to cross if you are careful and kind to the ice.

The Great World Tree - The vast tree whose roots and branches hold the whole world together, from the deep roots to the high nest of the eagle. A squirrel runs along it all day, carrying news.

The Hearth Hall - The cosy turf-roofed longhouse at the heart of the village, the heroes' home, where the great hearth-fire keeps everyone warm through the long winter.

The Rainbow Bridge - A shimmering bridge of soft colours arching from the fjords up to the high halls of the gods. It holds firm for those who cross it with a kind and honest heart.

The Whispering Pines - A snowy forest of tall dark pines where the wind carries soft voices, and a friendly hearth sprite likes to play and point lost travellers the right way.

Characters

Edda the Saga-Keeper - The kind old story-keeper of the Hearth Hall, who knows every saga of the fjords and sends the heroes out with a warm word and a good gift.

Freya the Kind - The warm-hearted goddess who watches over the fjords, and who smiles on heroes that win by thinking and caring rather than by force.

Creatures

Nori the Tomte - A small, kindly hearth sprite in a red cap who looks after the longhouse and loves to hand out helpful hints, and the odd harmless prank, to folk he likes.

Ratatosk the Squirrel - A quick, chattery red squirrel who races up and down the Great World Tree all day, carrying messages between everyone, though he does sometimes muddle them up.



The Aurora Spirits - Gentle spirits of the northern lights whose dancing fills the winter sky with colour. When they are happy and brave, the long night glows with teal, green and purple.



The Lonely Frost Giant - A huge giant of pale blue ice who sits in the way of travellers. He looks fearsome, but he is really just cold and lonely, and a warm word and a shared fire do more than any axe.

The Two Ravens - A pair of wise black ravens, Thought and Memory, who fly over all the fjords and bring back news. They nod kindly to heroes who travel with good intentions.

Items

The Ball of Red Yarn - A ball of bright red wool. Tie one end where you start and you can always follow it back, however far you wander.

The Everwarm Ember - A glowing coal from the great hearth that never goes cold. It can carry the warmth of home safely across the coldest, darkest night.

The Warm Honey Bun - A soft sweet bun, still warm from the hearth. Shared with a lonely giant, it can turn a frown into a friend.

Words to Know

Courage - A warm, steady heart on the longest, darkest night. Courage is not being unafraid; it is being kind and clever even when you are afraid.

Heart - Care for others and a place by the fire for everyone. The greatest heroes of the fjords are the ones who share, help, and stand by a friend.

Wit - Quick thinking and a clever plan. In the north, a good idea is worth more than a strong arm, and a riddle is solved with a cool head.

Idea Bank: The Snowlit Fjords of the North

Improv prompts for the grown-up. When the children want to try something the page did not plan for, reach in here. Nothing is a wrong answer; every idea bends toward warmth, cleverness, and nobody losing.

If the heroes are stuck

- Nori the Tomte pops out from under a snowy log, hums a little tune, and points his red cap toward the next clue.
- The Two Ravens circle overhead and drop a single feather on the right path.
- Edda the Saga-Keeper's voice drifts on the wind with the first line of an old saga that holds a hint.
- Let the heroes spend an energy star to "remember something Grandfather once said".

Friendly faces to drop in

- A reindeer with frost on its antlers who will share the way for a kind word.
- A pair of otters sliding on the ice who know a shortcut across the fjord.
- A snow hare who has lost a mitten and could use a hand.
- A sleepy bear cub who only wants someone to share the warm by the fire.

Gentle troubles to solve

- A bridge of ice that will only hold those who cross it gently and together.
- A snowdrift that has buried a friend's doorway, needing many small hands.
- A muddle of footprints in fresh snow to read and follow.
- A lantern gone dark that needs a spark of the everwarm ember and a brave breath.

Ways to win that are not winning

- Make the frost giant laugh instead of moving him aside.
- Trade a honey bun for a story instead of for the way through.
- Sing with the aurora spirits until they are brave enough to dance.
- Leave the place warmer and kinder than you found it.

Northern flavour to sprinkle

- The crunch of snow, the smell of woodsmoke, breath misting in the cold.
- Amber windows glowing across the dark, a hearth crackling, wool and fur and warm mittens.
- The hush of a forest under snow, and the slow green ripple of the aurora overhead.

Stories in this world

Ratatosk's Muddled Message (young). The Great World Tree is huge.

The Long Winter's Night (older). Tonight is the longest night of the whole year.

The Lost Little Aurora (young). It is winter in the fjords, and the long night should be full of colour.

Wits and Wonder

World Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.